



The History of Vaccines



Have you heard of the term 'vaccines' before? What is a vaccine? When were vaccines first invented? Why are they so important in the medical world? To begin with, vaccines are a special type of medicine that helps your body build up its own immune protection against diseases.

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All around the world, doctors and medical specialists use vaccines to prevent certain diseases. With vaccines, we can prevent millions of deaths from diseases like tetanus, small pox, measles and diphtheria.

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When a person is vaccinated against a disease, they receive a tiny, weakened dose of the bacteria or virus that causes the disease. The body's immune system jumps into action and creates antibodies. If the body encounters this disease again, the antibodies know to fight it off.

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The history of vaccines is important. In 1796, the world's first successful vaccine was developed by an English doctor called Edward Jenner. Jenner found out that people infected with cowpox were able to be immune to smallpox. A vaccine for smallpox was then created from this knowledge.

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Louis Pasteur, a French scientist, was also prominent in the research into vaccines. In the 1880s, Pasteur developed the first vaccine for rabies.

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In the 19th and 20th centuries, polio was one of the most feared viral diseases in the world. Thanks to Dr. Jonas Salk and his work on the polio vaccine, there is now a way to prevent this disease.

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In modern history, vaccines have also been developed for tuberculosis, mumps, measles, cholera, influenza and more recently for coronavirus, which causes COVID-19. Vaccines are often considered one of the greatest medical advances in the history of medicine.

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